

Granting Bahá'ís in Egypt the Right to Possess Identity Cards

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

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To the Bahá'ís of Egypt

Dearly loved Friends,

The significance of the landmark ruling accorded to your community by the Supreme Administrative Court in Egypt has emerged into sharper focus since it was announced in March. At last, your steadfast refusal to submit to a glaring injustice yielded its long-anticipated fruit: the right of citizenship, an entitlement so basic that its denial to you attracted the sustained attention and concern of observers both within your own country and abroad. Although the prolonged delay in implementing the ruling cast a shadow over our initial feelings of gladness that your call for fair treatment had been heard, we nevertheless welcome without reservation the court's public assertion that you should not have to deny your faith in order to obtain official documents stating your identity. Many supported you in your struggle, and many from outside your community stand to benefit from the positive outcome. This milestone deserves to be marked, and for the dignity, integrity and commitment to principle you evinced in reaching this point, you have won the respect of the fair-minded.

Sadly, there exist those who remain bitterly opposed to even so modest an advance. Hardly had the news emerged that you had succeeded in securing your right to obtain an identity card than the believers in al-Shuraniya were subjected to fierce attacks upon their properties. Even the home of a Muslim neighbour was destroyed by the frenzied mob. It distressed us all the more to learn that children are among those most acutely affected by this outburst of religious fanaticism—a phenomenon described by Bahá'u'lláh as “a world-devouring fire”, a “desolating affliction” from which “the Hand of Divine power can, alone, deliver mankind”. Our thoughts and prayers are with those caught up in the maelstrom that was unleashed in Sohag, and we regard with admiration the exemplary fortitude and patience they have shown, young and old, in coping with their hardships.

These acts of violence, and the continuing hostility emanating from some quarters, are unhappy confirmations that misconceptions persist in Egypt concerning your aims and motives. To dispel these misunderstandings must now be your constant aim; however, the manner in which you pursue this objective should be in marked contrast to the approach which won you your rights as citizens. With that favourable verdict a new chapter has opened, one that must be characterized not by the plaintive call of the unjustly maligned but by an attitude of service to others that militates against your being drawn into conflict and fruitless disputation. You shall persuade others of your true intentions through your wholehearted implementation of a framework for action finely tempered through the experience of your fellow believers on every continent. We confidently expect the youth to excel in this vital task—indeed, to eclipse their previous accomplishments. With a determination surpassing that which you exhibited in defence of your basic rights, you must resolve to engage more and more well-wishers of mankind in those activities that have proven their capacity to contribute to the betterment of the world. Does not every concerned parent yearn for the means of developing their children's spiritual faculties, laying within them the foundations of a noble and upright character? Would not every young person flourish in a programme that helps to form a

strong moral identity in the critical years of early adolescence and empowers participants to contribute to the well-being of society? Would the lives of your friends and neighbours not be enriched by the profound conversations that naturally arise from systematic study of the Creative Word and the exploration of its implications? Are not the complementary ideals of spiritual and material progress also dear to the hearts of Egyptians, heirs to a civilization as celebrated as any in recorded history? Harbour no doubt that, in a land that was home to some of the Faith's earliest Arab adherents and admirers, there exist countless fair-minded, truth-seeking souls whose spirits will rejoice in apprehending the true purpose underlying the Revelation of Bahá'u'lláh: a goal no less lofty than the rehabilitation of the world.

Seize the moment. With faith in the confirmations vouchsafed to you, grasp every opportunity to prove the extent of your goodwill towards your country and its people. Share with those you encounter your unalterable belief in the oneness of humankind and your conviction that consciousness of this truth serves to erase all traces of hatred and fanaticism from the heart. Impress upon all who offer you a hearing ear your abiding faith in their capacity to play a part in an ever-advancing civilization. By the excellence of your character and adherence to the dictates of wisdom, by your rejection of contention and strife, by the moderate language of your discourse, you can demonstrate to your society a much needed model of what it means to reflect a faith in Almighty God through one's life and to be citizens worthy of this blessed Day.

Beloved friends: Our hands are lifted up in fervent entreaty to the Ancient Beauty that He may inspire you and fortify your efforts to nurture, in His Name, the seeds of love and fellowship in people's hearts.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]